

D383

Search Engine Optimization

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

An SEO specialist at a hiking-gear retailer compresses images to speed up page loads, fixes broken redirects, and submits an XML sitemap. The retailer's founder once climbed Denali. Which category of SEO is this work?

- A. On-page SEO
- B. Technical SEO
- C. None; SEO is only about keywords
- D. Off-page SEO

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity is an example of off-page SEO?

- A. Rewriting page headings to include target keywords
- B. Buying 5,000 links from a link farm
- C. Earning a link from a respected outdoor magazine's gear review
- D. Fixing crawl errors reported in Search Console

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A bakery's page ranks 12th for "gluten-free birthday cake Denver." Its title tag just says "Home," and its meta description is blank. The bakery uses only organic flour. Which change is most likely to improve the ranking?

- A. Write a keyword-rich meta description, the main ranking factor.
- B. Rewrite the title tag and main heading around "gluten-free birthday cake Denver."
- C. Repeat the keyword 40 times on the page.
- D. Add a paragraph about organic flour.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A page ranks third for its main keyword but gets a low click-through rate from search results. Which element most directly improves clicks without changing rank?

- A. More backlinks
- B. A clearer, more compelling meta description
- C. Nothing; click-through depends only on position
- D. An XML sitemap

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A searcher types “buy trail running shoes size 10.” A running store has a blog post titled “The History of Trail Running” and a trail-shoe category page. The store sponsors a local 10K race. Which page should target this query?

- A. The trail-shoe category page
- B. The homepage
- C. The history blog post
- D. A page about the 10K sponsorship

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

What search intent does the query “what is pronation in running” show?

- A. Commercial investigation
- B. Navigational
- C. Informational
- D. Transactional

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A new custom-furniture site with low domain authority competes with national chains. Its photographer shoots with a mirrorless camera. Which keyword should it target first?

- A. “handmade walnut coffee table Portland” (300 searches a month, low difficulty)
- B. “furniture,” since broad terms always convert best
- C. “mirrorless camera furniture photos”
- D. “sofa” (500,000 searches a month, very high difficulty)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A dental practice has 20 backlinks. A vendor offers 2,000 links from unrelated overseas directories for \$99. A local newspaper wants to quote the dentist in a health article that would link to the practice. The practice's lobby has a large fish tank. Which link strategy is better?

- A. Both are equally good, since every link always counts the same.
- B. Buy the 2,000 directory links.
- C. Get a link from an aquarium supply store.
- D. Earn the link from the local newspaper article.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A company wants its staging site kept out of search results. It blocks the site in robots.txt, yet some staging URLs still appear in results. The staging server is hosted in Virginia. What is the right fix?

- A. Move the staging server to another region.
- B. List the staging URLs in the XML sitemap.
- C. Password-protect the staging site, or allow crawling and add a noindex tag.
- D. Add more lines to robots.txt.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

The same product page is reachable at two URLs, one with a tracking parameter. What tells search engines which version is preferred?

- A. A 301 redirect of both URLs to the homepage
- B. A robots.txt block on the product folder
- C. A noindex tag on both URLs
- D. A rel=canonical tag pointing to the clean URL

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A fintech blog with a blue logo has 60 posts about budgeting, but none of them link to each other and there is no main overview page. What structure fix helps most?

- A.** Create a budgeting pillar page and link it to and from the related posts.
- B.** Redesign the blue logo.
- C.** Merge all 60 posts into one very long page.
- D.** Delete all but one post.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A lawn-service company with 12 trucks has five pages all optimized for “lawn aeration Tulsa,” and its ranking bounces among them. What is the best fix?

- A.** Add a sixth page for the same keyword.
- B.** Add the truck fleet size to every page.
- C.** Keep all five, since more pages always rank better.
- D.** Consolidate into one strong aeration page with 301 redirects, and retarget the others to different keywords.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

An SEO specialist at a hiking-gear retailer compresses images to speed up page loads, fixes broken redirects, and submits an XML sitemap. ~~The retailer's founder once climbed Denali.~~ Which category of SEO is this work?

Target word: classify the work **Decides:** Speed, redirects, and sitemaps are infrastructure.

A	Confusion set	On-page covers content and HTML elements like titles and headings.
B	Correct	Crawlability and performance are technical SEO.
C	Absolute language	Site infrastructure is a core part of SEO.
D	Adjacent category	Off-page is mainly about links and mentions from other sites.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

Which activity is an example of off-page SEO?

Target word: reverse: from category to activity **Decides:** Off-page = signals from other sites.

A	Confusion set	Headings are on-page.
B	Inverted operation	Link schemes violate guidelines and can harm rankings.
C	Correct	An earned external link is off-page.
D	Adjacent category	Crawl fixes are technical.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A bakery's page ranks 12th for "gluten-free birthday cake Denver." Its title tag just says "Home," and its meta description is blank. ~~The bakery uses only organic flour.~~ Which change is most likely to improve the ranking?

Target word: change that moves rank **Decides:** The title tag is a ranking signal and is empty of the keyword.

A	Confusion set	Meta descriptions mainly affect clicks, not rank.
B	Correct	Title and heading relevance affect ranking.
C	Inverted operation	Keyword stuffing harms quality and can hurt rank.
D	Camouflage	Answers the flour detail, not the target query.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

A page ranks third for its main keyword but gets a low click-through rate from search results. Which element most directly improves clicks without changing rank?

Target word: reverse: clicks, not rank **Decides:** The snippet text drives click appeal.

A	Adjacent category	Links affect rank, not snippet appeal.
B	Correct	The description shapes the snippet searchers read.
C	Absolute language	Snippet wording also changes click-through.
D	Confusion set	Helps discovery, not clicks.

5. Answer A Concept 3

A searcher types “buy trail running shoes size 10.” A running store has a blog post titled “The History of Trail Running” and a trail-shoe category page. ~~The store sponsors a local 10K race.~~ Which page should target this query?

Target word: page matched to intent **Decides:** “Buy” signals transactional intent.

A	Correct	A product page serves transactional intent.
B	Adjacent category	Fits navigational brand searches, not a specific buy query.
C	Confusion set	Serves informational intent.
D	Camouflage	Answers the race detail, not the searcher.

6. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

What search intent does the query “what is pronation in running” show?

Target word: reverse: from query to intent **Decides:** “What is” signals a learning need.

A	Adjacent category	No product comparison is implied.
B	Confusion set	No brand or site is named.
C	Correct	The searcher wants to learn.
D	Inverted operation	No buying signal in the query.

7. Answer A Concept 4

A new custom-furniture site with low domain authority competes with national chains. ~~Its photographer shoots with a mirrorless camera.~~ Which keyword should it target first?

Target word: first keyword to target **Decides:** Low authority favors low-difficulty, specific terms.

A	Correct	A winnable long-tail term with clear buying intent.
B	Absolute language	Broad terms have vague intent and heavy competition.
C	Camouflage	Answers the camera detail, not what buyers search.
D	Dropped element	Drops difficulty; a new site cannot compete for it.

8. Answer D Concept 5

A dental practice has 20 backlinks. A vendor offers 2,000 links from unrelated overseas directories for \$99. A local newspaper wants to quote the dentist in a health article that would link to the practice. ~~The practice’s lobby has a large fish tank.~~ Which link strategy is better?

Target word: better link **Decides:** Relevance and authority over volume.

A	Absolute language	Link value varies widely by source.
B	Inverted operation	Choosing quantity over quality risks a penalty.
C	Camouflage	Answers the fish-tank detail; not relevant to dentistry.
D	Correct	One relevant, authoritative, earned link beats bulk junk links.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A company wants its staging site kept out of search results. It blocks the site in robots.txt, yet some staging URLs still appear in results. ~~The staging server is hosted in Virginia.~~ What is the right fix?

Target word: fix for unwanted indexing **Decides:** Robots.txt blocks crawling, not indexing.

A	Camouflage	Location does not affect indexing.
B	Inverted operation	Invites search engines to index them.
C	Correct	Noindex must be seen to work; protection keeps it out entirely.
D	Confusion set	Still only blocks crawling; blocked pages can remain indexed.

10. Answer D Concept 6 • transfer

The same product page is reachable at two URLs, one with a tracking parameter. What tells search engines which version is preferred?

Target word: reverse: from duplicate problem to tag **Decides:** Duplicate content needs a preferred version.

A	Adjacent category	Loses the product page entirely.
B	Confusion set	Controls crawling, not which duplicate is preferred.
C	Dropped element	Removes both versions, dropping the page from results.
D	Correct	Canonical names the preferred version.

11. Answer A Concept 7

A fintech blog ~~with a blue logo~~ has 60 posts about budgeting, but none of them link to each other and there is no main overview page. What structure fix helps most?

Target word: structure fix **Decides:** Related content with no internal links.

A	Correct	A topic cluster shows depth and spreads authority.
B	Camouflage	Branding does not fix site structure.
C	Adjacent category	Loses focused pages that match specific searches.
D	Inverted operation	Throws away topical depth instead of organizing it.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A lawn-service company ~~with 12 trucks~~ has five pages all optimized for “lawn aeration Tulsa,” and its ranking bounces among them. What is the best fix?

Target word: fix cannibalization **Decides:** Five pages compete for one term.

A	Inverted operation	Makes the cannibalization worse.
B	Camouflage	Irrelevant to the keyword conflict.
C	Absolute language	Duplicate targeting splits signals.
D	Correct	One primary keyword per page ends the competition.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	On-page, off-page, and technical SEO	On-page = content and HTML on the page; off-page = signals from elsewhere, mainly links; technical = crawlability, speed, and site infrastructure.	Calling speed or sitemap work on-page, or link building technical.	A list of tasks to classify.
2	Title tags vs. meta descriptions	The title tag is a ranking signal and the clickable headline; the meta description mainly affects click-through, not ranking.	Writing a keyword-stuffed meta description to raise rank.	“Move ranking” vs. “get more clicks from the same position.”
3	Search intent	Match the page type to intent: informational to guides, navigational to the brand page, commercial to comparisons, transactional to product pages.	Sending a buy-now query to a blog post, or the reverse.	Words like “buy,” “best,” “what is,” or a brand name.
4	Long-tail keywords	Long-tail terms have lower volume but lower competition and clearer intent, so newer sites win them first.	Chasing the biggest head term regardless of difficulty.	A low-authority site choosing between a broad term and a specific phrase.
5	Backlink quality	Relevant, authoritative, editorially earned links outweigh many low-quality ones; bought link schemes risk penalties.	Counting every link as equal.	An offer of many cheap links vs. one strong earned link.
6	Crawling vs. indexing controls	Robots.txt controls crawling, not indexing; noindex keeps a crawlable page out of results; canonical tags name the preferred duplicate.	Using robots.txt to remove pages from search results.	Unwanted URLs appearing in results, or duplicate URLs.
7	Topic clusters and internal links	A pillar page on a broad topic links to and from detailed cluster pages, showing topical depth and spreading authority.	Leaving related posts unlinked or merging everything into one page.	Many related posts with no internal linking.
8	Keyword mapping and cannibalization	Map one primary keyword to one page; several pages targeting the same term compete and weaken each other.	Adding more pages for the same keyword.	Rankings that bounce among several pages for one term.

Course scope (public description): Search Engine Optimization, otherwise known as SEO, teaches on-page, off-page, and technical aspects of SEO for organically improving ranking and awareness. Digital marketing requires marketers to understand online consumer search behaviors; search engine optimization (SEO) is a key part of an organization’s digital marketing strategy. This includes processes and best practices used to increase their visibility in search engines. Learners will discover SEO strategies focusing on website structure, search engines, keyword research and mapping, and page-level optimization. Learners will gain practical experience using a simulation in which they will optimize ranking and visibility to consumers. In this course, learners will have the opportunity to complete HubSpot’s SEO certification to learn industry best practices and to enhance marketability within the marketing profession.